

Quantifiers are in Different Positions: *all* and *both* in English, German, and Yiddish

Dorian Roehrs, UNT

This paper argues that the quantifiers for *all* and *both* can occur in different positions in the three closely related languages English, German, and Yiddish. Such differences have to be taken into consideration in the explanation of ungrammatical cases, as briefly exemplified here. All these languages allow these two quantifiers to be in the DP-layer. However, they vary as regards the predeterminer and the postdeterminer positions. Since Yiddish is the most tolerant language – it allows both quantifiers to occur in all three positions, the restrictions in the other languages can presumably not involve a strong account.

1. Introduction

Concord holds between different elements of the noun phrase; that is, determiners, adjectives, and nouns agree in phi-features and case. Based on data originally observed by Haider (1988, 1992), Bayer (2015) discusses the ungrammaticality of the following constructions where a Saxon Genitive is sandwiched between a quantifier and a head noun:

- (1) a. * all-e Marias Bücher (German)
all-INFL Mary's books
'all Mary's books'
b. * beid-e Marias Bücher
both-INFL Mary's books
'both Mary's books'

He proposes that (1a) is out due to the disruption of an agreement chain, and he tentatively extends this proposal to (1b). This is illustrated in schematic form below, where Poss stands for possessor:

- (2) [QP Q-INFL [DP POSS [D' -s [NP N-INFL]]]]
+AGR -AGR +AGR

Specifically, the non-agreeing suffix *-s*, indicated above by *-AGR*, disrupts an agreement chain, explaining the ungrammaticality of these constructions.

First, I will show that the quantifiers *alle* 'all' and *beide* 'both' can be in different positions in German: While both elements can be in the DP-layer, *alle* can also be higher than the DP-layer, but *beide* can also be lower than the DP-layer. This means that Bayer's account of (1a) does not carry over to (1b). In other words, (1b) is independently out, as *beide* cannot occur above the DP-layer.

Second, I will show a bit more generally that quantifiers can be located in different positions in English, German, and Yiddish. Exemplifying with the words for *all* and *both*, all languages considered here allow these two types of quantifiers to occur in the DP-layer. In addition, all

languages tolerate *all* to be in predeterminer position. Importantly, there are also some cross-linguistic differences. While *both* can occur above the DP-layer in English, it cannot in German. Conversely, while *both* cannot occur in postdeterminer position in English, it can in German. Yiddish is different – it tolerates both types of quantifiers to occur in all three positions.

It will become clear that the DP-layer plays an important role: The DP-layer of definite DPs must contain an overt element – under certain conditions, this layer attracts words for *all* and *both*, elements that can, at least in principle, be merged in different positions.

The paper is organized as follows. First, I turn to the discussion of where *alle* and *beide* can appear in the German noun phrase. To establish some points of reference, I discuss English *all* and *both*, where the facts are fairly clear and uncontroversial. In Section 3, I discuss the facts in Yiddish. Section 4 addresses English *all*, German *all*, and Yiddish *al*, the latter two involving the uninflected variants of the universal quantifier. The conclusion in Section 5 closes the paper.

2. Different Structural Positions of Quantifiers in English and German

In this section, I consider the possible positions of *alle* ‘all’ and *beide* ‘both’. I start by repeating the cases from the introduction:

- (3) a. * all-e Marias Bücher
all-INFL Mary’s books
‘all Mary’s books’
b. * beid-e Marias Bücher
both-INFL Mary’s books
‘both Mary’s books’

Taking the data at face value, one could be inclined to give them the same analysis. In fact, Bayer (2015) tentatively suggests just that, namely that the Saxon Genitive disrupts an agreement chain in (3b) just as it does in (3a):

- (4) [QP Q-INFL [DP POSS [D’ -S [NP N-INFL]]]]
+AGR -AGR +AGR

However, as also noted by Bayer, *beide* does not behave like *alle* in all other respects. Unlike *alle* in (5a), *beide* can occur in postdeterminer position (5b):

- (5) a. * Marias all-e Bücher
Mary’s all-INFL books
b. Marias beid-e Bücher
Mary’s both-INFL books
‘both Mary’s books’

In what follows, I will argue that (3b) is independently out: Although the data point is consistent with an ill-formed agreement chain, its ungrammaticality has nothing to do with it. Rather, *beide*

cannot occur in predeterminer position. This discussion culminates in demonstrating that some quantifiers can be in different positions cross-linguistically.

Let us consider the positional options of *alle* and *beide* in more detail. Here I provide some English examples. Their contrast to German will make the points under discussion clearer.

2.1. English *all* vs. German *all* and *alle*

Starting with English, *all* must precede determiner elements (6) to the extent they are present (7):

- (6) a. all his books
b. all these books

- (7) a. all books
b. * the all books

The same facts hold for German, with the qualification that all determiner elements have strong inflections:

- (8) a. all(-e) sein-e Bücher
all-ST his-ST books
'all his books'
b. all(-e) dies-e Bücher
all-ST these-ST books
'all these books'
- (9) a. all*(-e) Bücher
all-ST books
'all books'
b. * di-e all-e(-n) Bücher
the-ST all-ST(/-WK) books

It is interesting to note that the inflection on German *alle* is optional when a possessive determiner or demonstrative is present (8a-b) but obligatory when a determiner is absent (9a). Given this difference in inflectional distribution on *all*- and the correlated presence or absence of a determiner in German, we can suggest that there are two different positions for German *all(e)* in (8) vs. *alle* in (9a), and presumably the same holds for the distributions of English *all* in (6) vs. (7a).

For German, Pafel (1994: 265-66) proposes that quantifiers like *alle* and *all* involve complex lexical entries of the category D. Specifically, inflected *alle* is right-adjoined to a null determiner, and this complex determiner takes a DP as its complement (10a). By contrast, uninflected *all* is left-adjoined to an overt determiner, and this complex determiner takes an NP as its complement (10b). As indicated by A below, the quantifiers are taken to be adjectival elements:

- (10) a. [DP [D e_D *alle_A*] [DP *die Probleme*]]
all.INFL the problems
- b. [DP [D *all_A die_D*] [NP *Probleme*]]
all the problems

The left-adjunction structure in (10b) explains the ungrammaticality of **all Probleme* ‘all problems’ – *all* only adjoins to a determiner. However, there are also some issues.

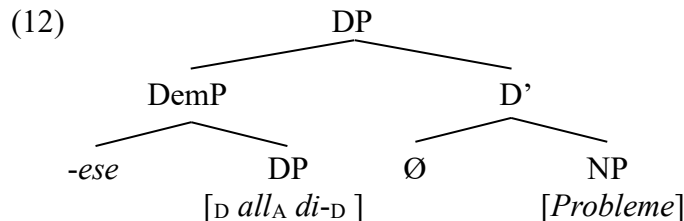
Note that the null determiner e_D in (10a) co-occurs with a DP complement and that the overt determiner *die_D* in (10b) co-occurs with an NP complement. One question that arises in this context is why this cannot be the other way around: Now, while *alle Probleme* ‘all problems’, analyzed alternatively as in (11a) below, is fine, **all die die Probleme*, provided in more detail in (11b) below, is not:

- (11) a. [DP [D e_D *alle_A*] [NP *Probleme*]]
- b. * [DP [D *all_A die_D*] [DP *die Probleme*]]

More has to be said. It is possible that we are missing a morpho-syntactic generalization here. Furthermore, as seen in (8) above, *all(e)* can also be combined with demonstratives and possessive determiners.¹ This means that the structure in (10b) needs to be extended to these types of determiners. In fact, every single possessive determiner (i.e., *mein-* ‘my’, *dein-* ‘your’, *sein-* ‘his’, etc.) must have its own complex lexical entry involving left-adjoined *all*. Again, it is likely that we are missing a generalization here.

Finally, it is usually assumed that demonstratives and possessives are in phrasal positions, that is, in Spec,DP (for demonstratives, see Bernstein 2001, Brugè 2002, Giusti 2002, Rauth & Speyer 2021; for possessive determiners, see Olsen 1989: 139, 1991: 53). If so, the structure in (10b) above will not extend to these cases straightforwardly, as these determiner elements involve complex elements.

Illustrating with demonstratives, it is often assumed that they basically consist of the definite determiner and a deictic component. While there are other options, one way to illustrate this is as follows, where the complex D head *all di-* raises to the Dem head *-ese*:



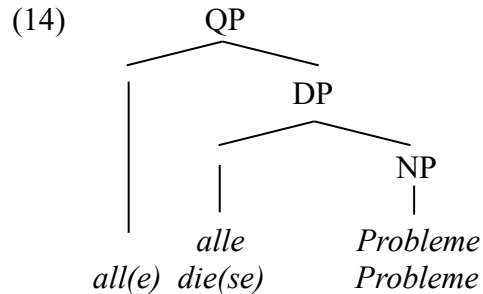
¹ Pafel (1994: 238) observes that uninflected *all* can precede demonstratives, possessive determiners, and definite articles but that inflected *alle* can only precede demonstratives and possessive determiners – definite articles preceded by *alle* as in (10a) are marked. Roehrs (2025a: 217) suggests that this might involve a phonological explanation.

Given the necessity to postulate so many related complex lexical entries, I opt for a morpho-syntactic analysis (for other issues of Pafel's analysis, see Roehrs 2026).

An alternative way to capture the difference between *all(e)* vs. *alle* is that quantifiers followed by a determiner are in a different phrasal level. This layer is above the DP and often labeled as QP (Bayer 2015; Cardinaletti & Giusti 2006: 40-43; Cirillo 2016; Giusti 1991: 443, 1997: 114-116; Julien 2005: 131). In other words, there are two phrasal levels that can house quantifiers:

- (13)
- | | | |
|---------------|-------------|-----------|
| QP | DP | |
| <i>all</i> | <i>all</i> | (English) |
| <i>all(e)</i> | <i>alle</i> | (German) |

I illustrate this in simplified fashion below:



Thus far in the discussion, English and German are basically the same. However, these two languages differ as regards *both* and *beide*.

2.2. English both and German beide

Similar to *all*, English *both* can occur before a determiner element (15a-b), it can be the determiner itself (16a), but it cannot follow the determiner (16b):²

- (15)
- | | |
|----|--------------------|
| a. | both his friends |
| b. | both these friends |

- (16)
- | | |
|------|----------------|
| a. | both books |
| b. * | the both books |

This is different for German *beide*. Notice that *beide* cannot precede a determiner (weak endings on the possessive or the demonstrative make the examples worse):

² I return to the data point in (16b) in Section 3.3, where I show that this pattern is possible when the head noun is missing.

- (17) a. ?? beid-e sein-e(?-n) Bücher
 both-ST his-ST(/-WK) books
 b. ?? beid-e dies-e(?-n) Bücher
 both-ST these-ST(/-WK) books

Vater (1991:18) judges *beide diese Bücher* in (17b) as fine. However, I side with Bhatt (1990: 217), who finds these types of example degraded. In order to settle this empirical issue, I conducted a search of *Datenbank für Gesprochenes Deutsch* (DGD; Database of Spoken German) on July 29, 2026. I examined 27 corpora of the database, which are listed in the Appendix. For the patterns in (17a-b) above, I checked every instance to make sure they were uttered by a native speaker of German in central Europe (in the attempt to exclude general multilingualism of speakers).

Starting with *beide* preceding a possessive determiner as in (17a), there were only three examples. All three are provided in (18). Note that all these examples have a connection to English: While the first two were uttered by students who were learning English as a foreign language, the third example was produced by an individual who had immigrated to England at the age of 19 (the identifications of the hits are provided under the examples and are enclosed in parentheses; the information is presented in the following order: acronym of corpus, acronym/pseudonym/name, year of birth, occupation, residence/dialect, parents, L2 languages; N A = information not available):

- (18) a. **beide meine** Elternteile leben so allein
 both my parents live so alone
 (FOLK/DH, AAC2, 1987/88, pupil, Aachen, German parents, English, Latin)
 b. **beide eure** freunde heißen philipp
 both your friends are.called Philipp
 (FOLK, Leonhard, 1985, student, Rhine-Franconian, N A, English, Latin)
 c. **beide meine** Kinder spielen Klavier
 both my children play piano
 (FEGB, Eric, 1919, language teacher, Vienna but immigrated to England at 19, N A, N A)

Notice that there were more surface strings of this type. However, it turned out that these involved *beide* as a floating quantifier. Providing two examples here, this is clear in (19a), where the head noun is in the singular, and in (19b), where the continuation of the sentences also speaks in favor of quantifier float:

- (19) a. Jetzt haben wir ... haben wir **beide unsere** Wohnung gekriegt (ZW)
 now have we have we both our apartment gotten
 b. sie hatten **beide ihre** Söhne in England ... Beide hatten zwei Söhne alle vier
 they had both their sons in England both had two sons all four
 Söhne waren in England. (FEGB)
 sons were in England

As to *beide* followed by a demonstrative as in (17b), this yielded one relevant example (20a). Again, it is very likely that the college teacher uttering this sentence also had some exposure to English as a foreign language. Finally, *beide* can also precede – what looks like – the definite article (20b). However, it turned out that all these cases involved *beide* followed by a relative clause introduced by the relative pronoun *die* ‘who’:

- (20) a. **beide diese** tunnel sind nach demselben prinzip gebaut worden
 both these tunnels have according.to the.same principle built been
 (FOLK, Walter, 1934, college teacher, Northern Low German, N A, N A)
- b. und äh äh **beide die** jetzt da gesessen sind äh (DH)
 and ... both who now there sat have ...

Note that the absence of *beide* preceding the definite article might be related to the markedness of *alle die Noun* (see Footnote 1). Finally, it is worth pointing out that while a total of four examples were identified – all in the nominative/accusative, there were no examples in the dative or genitive.

Turning to *beide* following a determiner, these cases exhibit the following patterns:

- (21) a. sein-e beid-en Bücher
 his-ST both-WK books
 ‘both his books’
- b. dies-e beid-en Bücher
 these-ST both-WK books
 ‘both these books’
- c. di-e beid-en Bücher
 the-ST both-WK books
 ‘both the books’

Unlike the four instances discussed above, the types of patterns in (21) are much more frequent. Table 1 presents the raw numbers of my search, totaling 2,130 hits. Specifically, given the high number and the fact that these are not controversial patterns, I did not check every example for relevance (note that *ihre* in *ihre beiden* below is three-way ambiguous: ‘her’, ‘their’, and ‘your(formal)’):

Table 1: Raw Numbers of *beide* Following a Determiner in DGD (July 29, 2026)

	Nom/Acc	Dat	Gen
<i>meine beiden</i>	96	13	0
<i>deine beiden</i>	2	1	0
<i>seine beiden</i>	13	5	0
<i>ihre beiden</i>	9	8	0
<i>unsere beiden</i>	26	1	1
<i>eure beiden</i>	0	1	0
<i>diese beiden</i>	160	120	26
<i>die beiden</i>	1,095	446	107
Totals	1,401	595	134
Overall Total	2,130		

Taking all the instances above at face value, the four examples present less than 0.2 percent of the total number of 2,134 ($= 2,130 + 4$) – a vanishingly small amount. I interpret this such that *beide* cannot precede determiner elements in German. Having said that, there were no self-corrections by any of the speakers of the four examples. This may provide some confirmation that these do not involve very strong grammaticality judgments as indicated in (17) above.

Taken together, these data points make German *beide* different from English *both* (but see also Section 3.3). As perhaps expected, German *beide* can also be a determiner. Like other determiners, it triggers a weak ending on a following adjective (22a-b). Furthermore, we have already observed that *beide* has to follow a determiner if there is one. In fact, if *beide* follows a determiner, it behaves like a regular adjective in that it takes a weak ending (22c):

- (22) a. beid-e klein-en Bücher
 both-ST small-WK books
 ‘both small books’
 b. ?? beid-e klein-e Bücher
 both-ST small-ST books
 c. di-e beid-en klein-en Bücher
 the-ST both-WK small-WK books
 ‘both the small books’

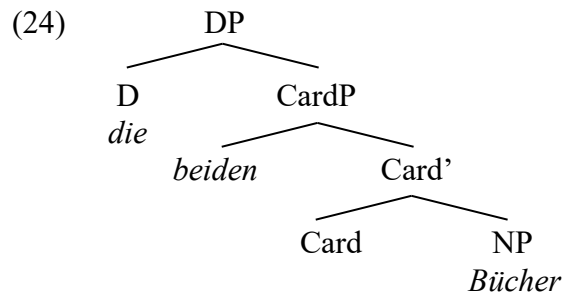
We conclude that besides a determiner, *beide* can also be an adjectival element in a lower position in German.

To sum up thus far, there are three positions for *both/beide*. Consider (23). Note that both languages share the option of having this element in the DP-layer but that they differ in the second option in that English *both* can occur above the DP-level but German *beide* below it. I take the latter element to be an adjectival quantifier in CardP, a structural layer between determiners and adjectives. To be clear then, none of the two languages discussed thus far

tolerates this element in all three positions (but as documented below, *ale* and *beyde* in Yiddish can appear in all three positions):

- (23)
- | | | | |
|-------------|--------------|---------------|-----------|
| QP | DP | CardP | |
| <i>both</i> | <i>both</i> | | (English) |
| | <i>beide</i> | <i>beiden</i> | (German) |

Beide in a lower position is illustrated in simplified fashion below:



This structure may be more complex. Below are three googled examples (out of many hits), where *zwei* ‘two’ can precede *beide* ‘both’ (note that these have a colloquial flavor):

- (25)
- | | |
|----|---|
| a. | Die zwei Beiden frisch Verliebten |
| | the two both newly fallen.in.love.ones |
| b. | die zwei beiden Freistädte Rust und Eisenstadt |
| | the two both free.cities Rust and Eisenstadt |
| c. | die zwei beiden Rettungsschwimmer Paula und Maxi |
| | die zwei beiden lifeguards Paula and Maxi |

Comparing (13) to (23), English *all* and *both* have the same distributional options but German *all(e)* and *beide* do not. Continuing with German, we may state that if only *alle* or *beide* is present, they surface in the DP-level. Presumably, both elements share the option of surfacing in the DP-layer, as definite DPs require an overt element in the DP-level (Alexiadou 2005, Cirillo 2016, Julien 2005, and Longobardi 1994). Alexiadou (2005) assumes that D has definiteness features to check, requiring that the DP-level be filled. Speaking in a theory-neutral way, the DP-layer attracts a determiner. Alternatively, if a(nother) determiner is present, it forces the quantifier to be in a higher (*alle*) or lower (*beide*) position, as German only allows one determiner to surface in the DP-layer. Traditionally, this is accounted for by the Doubly-filled DP Filter (e.g., Abney 1987: 271; Giusti 1997: 109, 2002: 70; but see also Roehrs 2019 for an explanation involving complex feature bundles for definiteness). Given these remarks, it is clear that the DP-layer plays an important part in the distribution of determiner(-like) elements in definite DPs in German.

The different positions of *alle* and *beide* in German are confirmed by other facts. In this language, both elements can co-occur provided *beide* involves the adjectival variant (the weak ending *-n* added to *beide* in (26a) makes the example perfect):³

- (26) a. all-e beid-e[?](-n) Bücher
all-ST both-ST(/-WK) books
'both (of the two) books'
b. * beid-e all-e(-n) Bücher
both-ST all-ST(/-WK) books

English disallows both elements to occur at the same time:

- (27) a. * all both books
b. * both all books

Although rare, both elements in German can also co-occur with a determiner separating them:

- (28) a. all(-e) dies-e beid-en
all(-ST) these-ST both-WK
'all these (two)'
b. all di-e beid-en
all the-ST both-WK
'all the (two)'

Here are two examples retrieved by a google search (note that (29a) involves an incomplete sentence marked by three dots):

- (29) a. Ich habe kürzlich all diese beiden...
I have recently all these both
'Recently, I have ...all these (two)...'
b. All diese beiden Elchbrüder wollen nur ihre Drachen hoch fliegen lassen
all these both elk.brothers want only their kites high fly let
'All these (two) guys only want to let their kites fly high.'

With this in place, we are now ready to return to the data from the beginning of this section. With the possessor *Maria* in Spec,DP, it is clear that *beide Marias Bücher* is independently out, as *beide* cannot appear in QP in the first place. In other words, the ungrammaticality of this

³ Disregarding cases of floating quantifiers, Duden (2016: 310) provides *alle beide* without an overt noun (see also examples in DGD). Note, though, that *alle beide* can, marginally, occur with an overt noun. DGD also shows *alle beiden*, and some of these instances do have an overt noun. Given these inflectional options of *beid-*, the two analyses for (26a) are presumably as follows:

(i) a. ? [QP alle [DP beide [NP Bücher]]]
b. [DP alle [CardP beiden [NP Bücher]]]

Note, however, that if (ia) is possible, it is not entirely clear why the following is completely out: **all beide Bücher* (cf. *all diese Bücher*). Possibly, quantificational determiners cannot be hosts to uninflected *all* (see Section 4 below).

The upshot of this discussion is that the possible structural positions of elements have to be taken into account in the discussion of agreement chains (see Roehrs 2025b, 2026). In fact, it has become clear in the comparison of English and German that quantifiers can be in different positions in different languages. Besides the DP-layer, they can also be above the DP-layer (English *both*; also Icelandic *margar* ‘many’, see Pfaff 2015: 84; and Old English *sum*, see Roehrs & Sapp 2018; more generally also Pfaff & Walkden 2024) or below the DP-layer (German *beide*; also Early New High German *alle* and Yiddish *ale* and *beyde*, see Roehrs & Sapp 2016: 144 and the next section). Note that the occurrence of quantifiers in the positions lower than QP seems to be dependent on the inflection on the quantifier. This point can be made more explicit with German and Yiddish. I start with a survey of the facts in Yiddish. In Section 4, I return to German.

3.1. *Yiddish al and ale*

Uninflected *al* can precede the definite article (30a). Interestingly, we find *al* and the definite determiner often spelled as one word (30b). The reduced form *alde* in (30c) may indicate a different (possibly grammaticalized) status of this combination (note in this context that this example involves an idiom):

- ⁴ Note that there is a major caveat here. The point just made in the text only holds if the grammaticality statuses of *beide Marias Bücher* and *beide seine Bücher* are the same. Above, the first was reported to be fully ungrammatical (*) by Bayer (2015), but the second was suggested to be marked (??) here. If there is indeed a grammaticality contrast, then Bayer's agreement chain may account for the difference in grammaticality. Note, however, that the two grammaticality judgments are not added; that is, ?? is not added to * (which equally holds for *alle Marias Bücher*, where *alle* can easily appear in predeterminer position), yielding perhaps **. I will leave this open for now.

- b. aldos doz-ik-e groys-e beyz
all.the here-ADJ-INFL great-INFL evil
'all this great evil'
 (from *Tanakh: Yirmeyohu*; Corpus of Modern Yiddish)
- c. Tsu al di / alde shvarts-e yor!
to all the / all.the black-INFL year
'Darn it!'
 (Lockwood 1995: 56)

That *al* having a special status may be true is shown by the fact that there are no examples of *al yene* ‘all those’ (for possible instances of *al* and a possessive article, see Footnote 5 below). Indeed, Birnbaum (1979: 256, 297) provides another reduced form (*aldis*) and states explicitly that if *al* precedes the definite article, it is not inflected, and the two are felt to form a single word. He points out that the two elements are joined together, which results in a weakened vowel (*aldos* > *aldis*).

As stated in Jacobs (2005), inflected *ale* can precede possessive determiners (31a). In addition, it can also precede demonstratives (31b). As expected, it can also occur without a determiner in the DP-layer (31c-d):

- (31) a. al-e mayn-e dray elter-e brider (Yiddish)
all-INFL my-INFL three older-INFL brothers
'all my three older brothers'
(Jacobs 2005: 240)
- b. al-e yen-e zakhn
all-INFL those-INFL things
'all those things'
(Weinreich 1999: 192)
- c. al-e (dayn-e) gut-e frages
all-INFL your-INFL good-INFL questions
'all (your) good questions'
(Jacobs 2005: 240)
- d. al-e bikher
all-INFL books
'all books'
(Jacobs 2005: 187)

Perhaps most interestingly, this language also allows this quantifier to follow determiners. In this case, the quantifier is always inflected:

- (32) a. di al-e shrayber (Yiddish)
these all-INFL writers
'all these writers'
(Birnbaum 1979: 297)

- (from *Di indische printsesin*, p. 82)

(33) a. zayn-e al-e kleyder (Yiddish)
his-INFL all-INFL clothes
'all this clothes'
b. Eriks al-e verk
Erik's all-INFL works
'all Erik's works'
(both from Lockwood 1995: 56)

(34) a. di al-e dray zakhn (Yiddish)
the all-INFL three things
'all the three things'
(from *Keynemsdorf*, p. 64)

b. di al-e tayer-e zakhn
the all-INFL expensive-INFL things
'all the expensive things'
(from *Röyte pomerantsen*, p. 97)

c. in di kimat al-e lender
in the almost all-INFL countries
'in almost all the countries'
(from *Forverts* 11/12/2014)

(35) a. Ikh hob zey al-e. (Yiddish)
I have them all-INFL
'I have them all.'
(Katz 1987: 120)

- b. di al-e, vos zey zenen geblibn
these all-INFL which they are stayed
'all those that stayed'
(Lockwood 1995: 124)
- c. mir zaynen shoyn al-e geven in Tsfas
we are already all-INFL been in Safed
'we have all been to Safed already'
(Lockwood 1995: 134)

To summarize the empirical facts, in predeterminer position, we find *al* before definite articles and *ale* before demonstratives and possessive determiners.⁵ In the DP-layer, we find inflected *ale*, and the same goes for the postdeterminer position. As far as I have been able to establish, *al* never occurs in the DP-layer or below, including cases when this quantifier is floated. Note that the distribution of this quantifier with the definite article seems to be special – it is the only context where it can be uninflected (and the article shows some signs of phonetic reduction). Interestingly, the uninflected form of this quantifier is also special in German. Before I turn to this, I briefly provide the facts of Yiddish *beyde*.

3.2. Yiddish beyde

Like *ale*, *beyde* can also occur in all three positions. Given the requirement that the DP-layer must be overt in definite DPs, we expect *beyde* 'both' to occur in this layer, just as it does in English and German. Similar to English, there is no independent morphological evidence that *beyde* can be in different positions – note in this regard that the strong/weak alternation of adjective inflections is only visible in singular neuter contexts in Yiddish (Roehrs 2015). Recalling the requirement that definite DPs must have an overt element in the DP-layer, I assume that (36) manifests a case of *beide* in this structural level:

- (36) beyd-e hent (Yiddish)
both-INFL hands

⁵ At first glance, one may note that exceptions seem to go in both directions. First, inflected *ale* can occasionally also occur before the definite article. However, it is not impossible that *di* might be a demonstrative here:

- (i) al-e di prekhtik-e bilder (Yiddish)
all-INFL the beautiful-INFL pictures
'all the beautiful pictures'
(from *Forverts* Radio Show 12/11/2011)

Second, in poetic language, one finds uninflected *al* before possessives (iia). However, I came across an example that uses an apostrophe to indicate the missing inflection (iib):

- (ii) a. al mayn-e blutn (Yiddish)
all my-INFL bloods
'all my bloods'
(googled: <http://www.cs.engr.uky.edu/~raphael/yiddish/nybc208866.html>)
- b. al' mayn-e treren-shtromen
all my-INFL tears-streams
'all my streams of tears'
(googled: https://github.com/pkarmstr/NYBC/blob/master/PyYiddish/mt-materials/cleaned_docs/nietzsche-zaratustra-2.txt)

Given these qualifying remarks, these cases may not present real exceptions after all.

Beyde can also follow a determiner, a pronominal determiner, and a possessive:

- (37) a. fun di beyd-e folks (Yiddish)
 from the both-INFL peoples
 ‘from the two people’
 (from Y. Leshtshinski’s *Di shprakhn bay yidn in umobhengikn poyln*, p. 592)
- b. mir beyd-e
 we both-INFL
 ‘we both’
 (from *Der tseykhen*, p. 240)
- c. fun zayn-e beyd-e zaytn
 from his-INFL both-INFL sides
 ‘from his two sides’
 (from Der Nister’s *Di mishpokhe mashber*)
- d. zayn bruder’s beyd-e hend⁶
 his brother’s both-INFL hands
 ‘both his brother’s hands’
 (from *Di indische printsesin*, p. 96)

Interestingly, *beyde* can also precede a possessive in Yiddish:⁷

- (38) a. oyf beyd-e mayn-e hent (Yiddish)
 on both-INFL my-INFL hands
 ‘on both my hands’
 (from *Keynemsdorf*, p. 26)
- b. beyd-e zayn-e eltern
 both-INFL his-INFL parents
 ‘both his parents’
 (from *Forverts* 02/22/2008)

Importantly, like in German, *beyde* cannot precede *di* ‘the, these’ (note that this is presumably not a semantic restriction as English has *both these friends*). A google search identified several hits of *beyde yene* (without a noun) but these cases appeared on sites that were not very well

⁶ Note that the plural for Yiddish ‘hands’ is usually spelled as *hent*.

⁷ Roehrs (2022: 362 fn. 11) points out that in very rare cases, a pronominal possessive can appear in a low pronominal position:

- (i) in der itstik-er undzer-er sotsyal-er lage (Yiddish)
 in the current-INFL our-INFL social-INFL situation
 ‘in our current social situation’
 (from *Forverts* 10/04/2009; Corpus of Modern Yiddish)

Note, though, that this singular possessive has an inflection despite the fact that it is not in an elliptical construction. Thus, besides its syntactic distribution, it also has the looks of an adjectival element. Be that as it may, given the very option of (i), a better, clearer example of *beyde* being located above the DP-layer would involve Saxon Genitives, strings of the sort *beyde SG Noun*. Currently, I do not have such an example. Given the grammaticality of *ale SG Noun* (see Section 4.3), I expect this to be possible.

edited. Thus, they need to be treated with caution. Given these remarks, it may be that *beide* can only precede possessives.

3.3. Summary of the Distributions and Cases of Partitives

The distributions of the two quantifiers in the three languages considered here are summarized in Table 2:

Table 2: Distribution of *all* and *both* in English, German, and Yiddish

	Predeterminer	DP-layer	Postdeterminer
English	<i>all</i> <i>both</i>	<i>all</i> <i>both</i>	
German	<i>all</i> _{DET} / <i>alle</i>	<i>alle</i> <i>beide</i>	<i>beide</i>
Yiddish	<i>al</i> _{ART} / <i>ale</i> <i>beyde</i> _{POSS}	<i>ale</i> <i>beyde</i>	<i>ale</i> <i>beyde</i>

Abstracting away from the DP-layer, there is no language here where *both* is only in predeterminer position, but *all* is only in postdeterminer position (the reverse of German). In fact, there seem to be some interesting dependencies: If *all* is in predeterminer position (as is the case in all three languages), then *both* can possibly also occur there. Put differently, the presence of *both* in this position entails the presence of *all* there. Also, if *both* is in postdeterminer position, then *all* can possibly also surface there. Again, put differently, the presence of *all* in this position entails the presence of *both* there. Finally, there is no language here that only has quantifiers in the DP-layer and/or in postdeterminer position. In other words, all languages allow quantifiers to precede (certain) determiners.

Above, I stated that D has features for definiteness that can be checked by a quantifier (cf. Alexiadou 2005). Now, if a quantifier can check the definiteness features of D, then the question arises what happens with the definiteness features on the quantifier when the quantifier appears in QP or CardP. I suggest that these quantifiers are not determiners but adjectival elements. As such, they do not have syntactic features for definiteness. If so, this makes the prediction that English should also allow adjectival quantifiers in a lower position. This is indeed the case with *both* (the data point below was gleaned from the TV sitcom *Everybody loves Raymond*), and possibly *all* (note that I looked through the first 100 hits of ‘the all of you’ and identified the instances in the (b)-type of examples):

- (39) a. the both of you
- b. We love the all, **the all of you** (from the song *In the Meantime* by Spacehog)
- b2. Thank you to **the all of you** that took part in the consultation on my draft Police and Crime Plan.
- b3. **The all of you** are doing an awful job of promoting a potential Top-10 NBA Finals Center Matchup of All-Time between Karl-Anthony Towns vs ...

- b4. Now now everyone, settle down, blizzards got enough systemslop for **the all of you**
- b5. Embrace **the all of you**
- b6. Praise **the all of you**

Crucially, though, these instances involve partitives, where the head noun is missing after *both* and *all*. This shows that while *both* and possibly *all* can appear in a lower position, partitive contexts involve different syntactic conditions for the non-pronunciation of head nouns.

If these considerations are on the right track, then this account shifts the question to why *die alle* (*Noun*) or *beide die* (*Noun*) are ungrammatical or marked in German. Presumably, the answer cannot involve a strong proposal, as these strings are possible in other languages.

4. The Status of English *all*, German *all*, and Yiddish *al*

4.1. German *all* and *alle* Revisited

Returning to German, the comparison between (40a) and (40b) shows that uninflected *all* can only occur if it precedes a determiner-like element. If no such element is present, this quantifier must be inflected (40c):

- (40) a. all di-e / dies-e / mein-e Bücher
all the-ST / these-ST / meine-ST books
'all the / these / my books'
- b. * all (zehn/gut-e) Bücher
all ten/good-ST books
- c. all-e (zehn/gut-en) Bücher
all-ST ten/good-WK books
'all (ten/good) books'

Recall that in Yiddish, uninflected *al* can only occur before the definite article; that is, its distribution is more restricted than in German.

4.2. Proposal for English, German, and Yiddish

English does not seem to have any special restrictions on *all* – it can appear before determiners, numerals, adjectives, and nouns alike. As to German, I propose that both inflected *alle* and uninflected *all* can be merged in QP and in the DP-layer. Inflected *alle* is not subject to any specific restrictions, except that it has to merge in the DP-layer to license a definite DP, if there is no other determiner element present, as in (40c) above.⁸ As for uninflected *all*, I propose that this is a deficient element that has to procliticize to a determiner element in German (40a). If no such element is present, it leads to ungrammaticality (40b), independent of whether or not *all* merges in QP or in the DP-layer. Yiddish is similar to German, except that uninflected *al* has to procliticize to the definite article. To be clear then, this proposal accounts for the fact that

⁸ If the discussion of quantifiers being able to check definiteness features is correct, then this means that the determiner variant of the quantifier is merged here.

uninflected forms of the quantifier can only occur before (certain) determiners, and inflected forms of the quantifier have a more unrestricted distribution.

4.3. *The Universal Quantifier Followed by a Possessor*

A potential complication arises if a possessor is added between the quantifier and the head noun. There are two main cases to be considered.

First, a Possessor Doubling construction can follow *all(e)* (for (41a), see Bayer 2015: 3; for (41b), see Karnowski & Pafel 2004: 182 fn. 13; a former reviewer):

- (41) a. all-e de-r Maria ihr-e Bücher
all-ST the-DAT Mary her-ST books
'all Mary's books'
b. all de-r Maria ihr-e Bücher
all the-DAT Mary her-ST books
'all Mary's books'

Interestingly, Haider (1992: 315) finds (41b) to be fully ungrammatical. As is apparent, there is some interspeaker variation here. I assume that this has to do with varying properties of uninflected *all*. Specifically, for Haider, *all* can only procliticize to a determiner that agrees in concord features with the larger DP; for the other scholars, *all* can procliticize to all determiners, agreeing or not.

Leaving out the proprial article, which is syntactically optional in Northern German (Nübling *et al.* 2015: 123-28), a clear contrast seems to arise, at least in my judgment:

- (42) a. (?) all-e Maria ihre Bücher
all-ST Mary her-ST books
'all Mary's books'
b. ?? all Maria ihre Bücher
all Mary her-ST books
'all Mary's books'

Again, this follows if *all* can only procliticize to determiners.⁹

The second case involves Saxon Genitives following *all(e)* (for (43a), see Bayer 2015: 3; for (43b), see Haider 1988: 53, 1992: 314; Karnowski & Pafel 2004: 182 fn. 13; Neef 2006: 290):

- (43) a. * all-e Marias Bücher
all-ST Mary's books
'all Mary's books'

⁹ I am not entirely certain why *all (gute) Bücher* 'all good books' is worse than (42b). Notice, however, that definite determiners and proper names have in common that they are definite elements. More tentatively, this might mean that uninflected *all* procliticizes to definite elements, preferably, definite determiners.

- b. * all Marias Bücher
all Mary's books
'all Mary's books'

Interestingly, here both inflected *alle* and uninflected *all* are ungrammatical. In fact, it is revealing to compare the data above to English and Yiddish, where these distributions are grammatical:

- (44) a. all John's friends (English)
(Cirillo 2016: 179)
- b. oyf al-e Peretses forlezungen in Varshe (Yiddish)
at all-INFL Perets' presentations in Warsaw
'at all Perets' presentations in Warsaw'
(from *Forverts* 11/27/2009)

Saxon Genitives preceded by the universal quantifier have an independent explanation, which involves the presence of morphological genitive case in German but its absence in English and Yiddish (see Roehrs 2025b).

5. Conclusion

This paper argued that the position of quantifiers has to be taken into account in the analysis of ungrammatical patterns – some cases are independently out, as quantifiers may not occur in certain positions in the first place. Second, making the discussion of the distribution of quantifiers a bit more general, it was shown that related quantifiers can occur in different positions in English, German, and Yiddish, with English having none of the two quantifiers in postdeterminer position (in non-partitive contexts), German has *beide*, and Yiddish has *ale* and *beyde*. Also, unlike English and Yiddish, German does not allow *beide* to occur in predeterminer position. Note that these restrictions can presumably not have a strong account, as they do not hold in the other, related languages.

Appendix – Corpora Searched for *beide* in DGD

These (and other) corpora are available online at <https://dgd.ids-mannheim.de/>:

- BB = Deutsche Mundarten: Kreis Böblingen
- BR = Biographische und Reiseerzählungen
- BW = Berliner Wendekorpus
- DH = Deutsch heute
- DR = Deutsche Mundarten: DDR
- DS = Dialogstrukturen
- EK = Elizitierte Konfliktgespräche
- FEGB = Flucht und Emigration nach Großbritannien
- FGOP = Fluchtgeschichten aus Ostpreußen
- FOLK = Forschungs- und Lehrkorpus Gesprochenes Deutsch

FR = Grundstrukturen: Freiburger Korpus
 GWSS = Gesprochene Wissenschaftssprache Kontrastiv
 HL = Deutsche Hochlautung
 HMAT = Hamburg Maptask Corpus (HaMaTaC)
 HMOT = Hamburg Modern Times Corpus (HaMoTiC)
 IPER = Interaktionsprofil und Persönlichkeit
 KN = Deutsche Standardsprache: König-Korpus
 MIKO = Mitschreiben in Vorlesungen
 MV = Binnendeutsche Varietäten: Varia
 OS = Deutsche Mundarten: ehemalige deutsche Ostgebiete
 PECI = Parallel European Corpus of Informal Interaction
 PF = Deutsche Umgangssprachen: Pfeffer-Korpus
 SEIG = Sprechen über die ehemalige innerdeutsche Grenze
 SPIG = Sprachsituation an der innerdeutschen Grenze
 SV = Deutsche Mundarten: Südwestdeutschland und Vorarlberg
 SW = Deutsche Mundarten: Schwarzwald
 ZW = Zwirner-Korpus

Primary Sources Quoted

Di indische printsesin. A roman fun libe, laydenshaft, rakhe un mord (The Indian Princess. A Novel of Love, Passion, Revenge and Murder) by Litvischer Filozof. 1930. New York: Hebrew Publishing Company.
Keynemsdorf (Nobody's Village) by Boris Sandler. 2010. (pdf version, downloaded originally from the *Forverts* website)
Röyte pomerantsen (Red Oranges) by Olsvanger, Immanuel. (ed). 1947. New York: Schocken Books.

References

Abney, Steven. 1987. The English Noun Phrase in its Sentential Aspect. Doctoral Dissertation, MIT.
 Alexiadou, Artemis. 2005. Possessors and (in)definiteness. *Lingua* 115: 787-819.
 Bayer, Josef. 2015. A Note on Possessor Agreement. In Hiroki Egashira, Hisatsugu Kitahara, Kazuo Nakazawa, Tadao Nomura, Masayuki Oishi, Akira Saizen, & Motoko Suzuki (eds.) *In Untiring Pursuit of Better Alternatives*, pp. 2-11. Tokyo: Kaitakusha.
 Bernstein, Judy B. 2001. Focusing the “right” way in Romance determiner phrases. *Probus* 13: 1-29.
 Bhatt, Christa. 1990. *Die syntaktische Struktur der Nominalphrase im Deutschen*. Tübingen: Gunter Narr Verlag.
 Birnbaum, Solomon A. 1979. *Yiddish. A Survey and a Grammar*. Toronto. University of Toronto Press.
 Brugè, Laura. 2002. The Positions of Demonstratives in the Extended Nominal Projection. In Guglielmo Cinque (ed.) *Functional Structure in DP and IP: The Cartography of Syntactic Structures*. vol.1, pp. 15-53. Oxford: Oxford University Press.

- Cardinaletti, Anna and Giuliana Giusti. 2006. The syntax of quantified phrases and quantitative clitics. In Everaert, Martin and Henk van Riemsdijk (eds.) *The Blackwell Companion to Syntax*. (Vol V), pp. 23-93. Oxford: Blackwell.
- Cirillo, Robert. 2016. Why all John's friends are Dutch, not German: On the determiner-like characteristics of the inflection on the universal quantifier in West Germanic. *Journal of Germanic Linguistics* 28(3): 179-218.
- Duden. 2016. *Duden: Grammatik der deutschen Gegenwartssprache*. Vol 4. (9th ed.) Mannheim: Dudenverlag.
- Giusti, Giuliana. 1991. The categorial status of quantified nominals. *Linguistische Berichte* 136: 438-454.
- Giusti, Giuliana. 1997. The categorial status of determiners. In Liliane Haegeman (ed.) *The New Comparative Syntax*, pp. 95-123. London and New York: Longman.
- Giusti, Giuliana. 2002. The Functional Structure of Noun Phrases. A Bare Phrase Structure Approach. In Guglielmo Cinque (ed.) *Functional Structure in DP and IP: The Cartography of Syntactic Structures*. vol.1, pp. 54-90. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Goldberg, David (ed.). 1993. *The Field of Yiddish. Studies in Language, Folklore, and Literature. Fifth Collection*. Evanston: Northwestern University Press.
- Haider, Hubert. 1988. Die Struktur der deutschen NP. *Zeitschrift für Sprachwissenschaft* 7 (1): 32-59.
- Haider, Hubert. 1992. Die Struktur der Nominalphrase. Lexikalische und funktionale Strukturen. In Ludger Hoffmann (ed.) *Deutsche Syntax. Ansichten und Aussichten. Institut für deutsche Sprache Jahrbuch 1991*, pp. 304-333. Berlin: Walter de Gruyter.
- Jacobs, Neil G. 2005. *Yiddish. A linguistic introduction*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- Julien, Marit. 2005. *Nominal Phrases from a Scandinavian Perspective*. Amsterdam: John Benjamins.
- Karnowski, Paweł and Jürgen Pafel. 2004. A topological schema for noun phrases in German. In Gereon Müller, Lutz Gunkel, and Gisela Zifonun (eds.) *Explorations in nominal inflection*, pp. 161-188. Berlin: Mouton de Gruyter.
- Katz, Dovid. 1987. *Grammar of the Yiddish language*. London: Duckworth.
- Lockwood, W.B. 1995. *Lehrbuch der modernen jiddischen Sprache*. Hamburg: Helmut Buske Verlag.
- Longobardi, Giuseppe. 1994. Reference and Proper Names: A Theory of N-Movement in Syntax and Logical Form. *Linguistic Inquiry* 25 (4): 609-665.
- Neef, Martin. 2006. Die Genitivflektion von artikellos verwendbaren Eigennamen als syntaktisch konditionierte Allomorphie. *Zeitschrift für Sprachwissenschaft* 25: 273-300.
- Nübling, Damaris, Fabian Fahlbusch, and Rita Heuser. 2015. *Namen. Eine Einführung in die Onomastik*. (2nd ed.) Tübingen: Narr.
- Olsen, Susan. 1989. Das Possessivum: Pronomen, Determinans oder Adjektiv? *Linguistische Berichte* 120: 133-153.
- Olsen, Susan. 1991. Die deutsche Nominalphrase as "Determinansphrase". In Susan Olsen & Gisbert Fanselow (eds.) *DET, COMP und INFL. Zur Syntax funktionaler Kategorien und grammatischer Funktionen*, pp. 35-56. Tübingen: Niemeyer.
- Pafel, Jürgen. 1994. Zur syntaktischen Struktur nominaler Quantoren. *Zeitschrift für Sprachwissenschaft* 13(2): 236-275.

- Pfaff, Alexander. 2015. Adjectival and Genitival Modification in Definite Noun Phrases in Icelandic. A Tale of Outsiders and Inside Jobs. Doctoral dissertation, University of Tromsø.
- Pfaff, Alexander & George Walkden. 2024. Adjectival articles in early Germanic. In Kristin Bech & Alexander Pfaff (eds.), *Noun phrases in early Germanic languages*, 323-364. Berlin: Language Science Press.
- Rauth, Philipp & Augustin Speyer. 2021. Adverbial reinforcers of demonstratives in dialectal German. *Glossa: A Journal of General Linguistics* 6(14). 1–24.
- Roehrs, Dorian. 2015. Inflections on Pre-nominal Adjectives in Germanic: Main Types, Subtypes, and Subset Relations. *The Journal of Comparative Germanic Linguistics* 18 (3): 213-271.
- Roehrs, Dorian. 2019. Three Typological Differences between the North and the West Germanic DP. *Journal of Germanic Linguistics* 31 (4): 363-408.
- Roehrs, Dorian. 2022. Prenominal Possessives in Yiddish: *mayn khaver* vs. *mayner a khaver*. *Linguistics: An Interdisciplinary Journal of the Language Sciences* 60 (2): 347-393.
- Roehrs, Dorian. 2025a. *Semantically vacuous elements in German: Adjectival inflections and the article ein*. Berlin: Language Science Press.
- Roehrs, Dorian. 2025b. The Nominal Left Periphery in German: Abstract Agreement Chains. (submitted Ms.).
- Roehrs, Dorian. 2026. Distributional and Inflectional Properties of Quantifying Words in German: Abstract Agreement Chains Revisited. (available at: <https://lingbuzz.net/lingbuzz/010053>).
- Roehrs, Dorian & Christopher Sapp. 2016. *Quantifying Expressions in the History of German: Syntactic reanalysis and morphological change*. Amsterdam: John Benjamins.
- Roehrs, Dorian & Christopher Sapp. 2018. Complex Quantifiers with Genitive and Concord in Old English and Beyond. *The Journal of Comparative Germanic Linguistics* 21 (3): 381-419.
- Vater, Heinz. 1991. Determination in der DP. In Susan Olsen & Gisbert Fanselow (eds.) *DET, COMP und INFL. Zur Syntax funktionaler Kategorien und grammatischer Funktionen*, pp. 15-34. Tübingen: Niemeyer.
- Weinreich, Uriel. 1999. *College Yiddish*. (6th ed.) New York City: YIVO Institute for Jewish Research.